Magic of Modernism

In its inaugural exhibition, ***Celebrating the Modernists of Indian Art***, Thapar Gallery in Delhi honours several pioneers

M F. Husain, F.N. Souza, S.H. Raza and many other distinguished artists feature in *Celebrating the Modernists of Indian Art*, the first exhibition at the new Thapar Gallery in Delhi. "It offers an exceptional opportunity to budding art enthusiasts and collectors to experience the genius of these iconic artists," says Ashish Thapar, founder, Thapar Gallery.

On view are 32 paintings and six sculptures that honour the legacy of the artists. "The curated collection, spanning decades of innovation, explores diverse themes and styles, creating a visual dialogue between the celebrated works of India's modernist masters," adds Thapar.

Divided into four sections, the show takes visitors through different genres. While the first section highlights the contribution of early modernists, including Progressives, the second introduces them to tantric and figurative abstractionists and still-life and landscapes. The third section focuses on figurative style with folk and tribal art, while the final section is dedicated to sculptures.

Thapar highlights some works that are not to be missed. For instance, Raza's 'OM' highlights the 'bindu' which is central to the pictorial language of the artist. "The dot is not only a visual tool but also a representation of the origin of life, the cosmos, and spiritual energy. It symbolises unity, creation, and the source of all existence," explains Thapar.

Another artwork, part of Krishen Khanna's 'Bandwala' series, features a blue bandwala as opposed to the often-seen iconic red attire. "The shift to blue tones deepens the sense of isolation, emphasising the transient nature of celebration and the musicians' perpetual anonymity," says Thapar.

There's also a painting by G.R. Santosh—a stunning neo-tantric interpretation of goddess Kali, where traditional iconography is transformed into a spiritual, geometric abstraction. ■

Divided into four sections, the show takes visitors through different phases of Indian modernism

–Geetika Sachdev

'Celebrating the Modernists of Indian Art' is on till March 22 at Thapar Gallery, Khasra No. 30, Crossing on NH-8, Kapashera Estate, Rajokri, New Delhi



MODERN VIEW A visitor at the newly opened Thapar Gallery

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